

Some sociologies of education: a history of problems and places, and segments and gazes

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Abstract

This paper focuses on some of the significant 'moments' and 'problems' and 'characters' and places which mark out a history of the sociology of education. It further explores some of the historical conjunctions of knowledge and practice to which the sociology of education contributed in its uneasy relations with schools and teachers and education policy. Three sets of tools and sorts of analysis, drawn from the work of Bernstein, Foucault and Bourdieu, are deployed to explore some of the turmoil and conflict which has characterised the sociology of education at different points in its history focusing on three of these. They are, the 1930s/1960s (Political Arithmetic), the 1970s (the New Sociology of Education) and the 1980s 'flight to policy studies' and particularly one aspect of this which produced the notion of 'school effectiveness'. The paper suggests some of the ways in which the sociology of education has played its part in the government and the detailed management of the population, through the changing construction of an unrelenting gaze (focused initially on families) and the concomitant development of a body of expert professional knowledge (teacher education) and, latterly, the management of the institutions of management (schools) and of the professionals themselves (teachers).

I will sketch here a sociology of the sociology of education, focusing on some of its significant 'moments' and 'problems' and their 'vicissitudes' and some of its 'characters' and places¹ and some of the historical conjunctions of knowledge and practice to which the sociology of education contributed in its uneasy relations with schools and teachers and education policy. All be it that there is no single, simple, coherent field of work that can be described as *the* sociology of education, although perhaps once there was. I shall interweave three sets of tools and sorts of analysis, drawn from the work of Bernstein, Foucault and Bourdieu, to explore some of the turmoil and conflict which has characterised the sociology of education at different points in its history focusing on three of these. They are, the 1930s/1960s (Political Arithmetic), the 1970s (the New Sociology of Education) and the 1980s (and what might be called 'the flight to policy studies' and particularly one aspect of this which produced the notion of

‘school effectiveness’).² In doing so I will suggest some of the ways in which the sociology of education has contributed to the work of government and the detailed management of the population, through the changing construction of an unrelenting gaze (focused initially on families) and the concomitant development of a body of expert professional knowledge (teacher education) and, latterly, the management of the institutions of management (schools) and of the professionals themselves (teachers) and the transformation of their expertise from knowledge to technical skills through teacher training and various forms of measurement and inspection (Ball, 2003). In other words, at different times and in different ways the sociology of education has created the ‘conditions of possibility’ and an ‘optics of power’ within which ‘the family’ and ‘the school’ have been constructed as sites of knowledge/research and for the deployment of technologies of policy.³

Bernstein and the sociology of education

In a paper published in the *British Journal of Sociology of Education* (Bernstein, 1999), one of only two he ever wrote for the main UK sociology of education journal, Bernstein outlined a theoretical analytical critique of knowledge in general and sociology and the sociology of education in particular which provides a schema for thinking about their fissures, discontinuities and paradigm disputes.

In Bernstein’s terms, sociology, in common with other social sciences, has a ‘horizontal knowledge structure’ which consists of ‘a series of specialised languages with specialised modes of interrogation and criteria for the construction and circulation of texts’ (Bernstein, 1999: 162) with no principles of integration. These specialised languages and their theoretical idiolects are ‘not translatable’ (Bernstein, 1999: 163), their speakers are exclusive and their relations are serial. Academic and social capital within the practice of sociology is bound up with the ‘defence of and the challenge of other languages’ (Bernstein, 1999: 163). Development in such a ‘horizontal discourse’, as he termed it, is not greater generality or abstraction or integration but the development of a new language which ‘offers the possibility of fresh perspectives, a new set of questions, a new set of connections, and an apparently new problematic, and most importantly, a new set of speakers’ (Bernstein, 1999: 163). His point is that the discreteness of these languages and the competition between the narcissism of their dedicated speakers are fundamental barriers to incorporation. Within such a discursive regime he suggests that the primary motivation lies in the ‘marketing’ of new languages. He goes on to describe what he calls the implicit ‘conceptual syntax’, or ‘weak grammars’ of horizontal knowledge structures, like those of sociology, which present particular problems to acquirers, in terms of knowing whether they are ‘really speaking or writing sociology’ (Bernstein, 1999: 164). Acquisition is tacit and depends upon acquiring the appropriate ‘gaze’; ‘a particular mode

of recognising and realising what counts as an “authentic” sociological reality’ (Bernstein, 1999: 165). This gives rise then to ‘segmental competences’ and ‘segmental literacies’ which rest upon an ‘obsession with language’ but also, inasmuch as these knowledge structures are retrospective, they are also ‘characterised by inherent obsolescence’ (Bernstein, 1999: 167). The segmentalising structures also ‘shatters any sense of an underlying unity’ (Bernstein, 1999: 170). The key problem for Bernstein was that the sociology of education is organised around commitments to ‘languages of dedication’ rather than to ‘a problem and its vicissitudes’ (Bernstein, 1999: 170).

Introduction

Developments and discontinuities within the sociology of education have been produced by changing patterns of relations within the field between its competing segments, relations between itself and adjacent fields or disciplines and its various engagements with social and political ‘problems’. With respect to the former, in the past 30 years it has been defined and redefined by a set of theoretical and methodological disputes or ‘paradigm wars’ between contending idiolects, and subject to various breakaways and splits which have created new sub-fields, even distinct, new disciplines. This has been markedly the case in the UK in recent inter-disciplinary relations, what Kant called ‘the conflict of the faculties’ (Bourdieu, 1988), which are increasingly complex especially in the wake of the postmodern ‘turn’. In particular, postmodernism ‘has spread like a virus through the disciplines of the social sciences and humanities eating away at the boundaries between them’ (MacLure, 2003: 4). Boundaries between sociology and philosophy, political science, geography and social psychology have become fuzzy and loose.⁴ Consequently it is sometimes difficult to say who is a sociologist of education and who is not and where the field begins and ends – as we shall see later. All disciplines may be regarded as fields of struggle and arenas of interest competition. They are made up of sets of ‘discourse communities’ (or what Bernstein calls ‘segments’ and ‘idiolects’) which ‘produce knowledge and establish the conditions for who speaks and who gets heard’ (Brantlinger, 1997). These interests have a number of dimensions: there is the personal – related to the satisfactions, reputations and status of those in positions of power and patronage, and expressions of identity; there are those more conventionally referred to as ‘vested’ – including the material rewards from career, position and publication; and the ideological, – matters of value, personal philosophy and political commitment. Such interests are at stake in decisions, appointments and influences which shape and change the field of sociology of education and its rewards. For example, they have been reflected in the efforts of scholars of colour, women, gay and lesbian and disabled scholars to rework the boundaries, the analytic tools and theoretical bases of the sociology of education; and in doing so, get positions and grants, get published, assert control of key journals and/or create new ones. Such

struggles take place, in an intellectual register, on the floor of conferences and in the pages of journals but they are also played-out, micro-politically, in editors' offices, in department meetings and in appointing committees. These struggles are also embedded in 'the hidden curriculum in graduate sociology departments' (Margolis and Romero, 2000) taking two forms. A 'weak' version defines and attempts to control what it means 'to be a sociologist' as part of a professionalisation process within which certain methods, topics, concerns and dispositions are validated as 'good sociology'. This is described by Bourdieu (Bourdieu, 1988: 56) as the 'corporeal hexis', 'the visceral form of recognition of everything which constitutes the existence of the group, its identity, its truth, and which the group must reproduce in order to reproduce itself'. The 'strong' form works to reproduce stratified and unequal social relations reinforcing, in particular, the control and influence of white, male scholars (see Bagilhole, 1993). In these terms the sociology of education has its own sociology; its own 'collective scientific unconscious', in Bourdieu's words, and its own particular conditions of production, which at different points in time have set different limits upon thought through the deployment of specific sets of theories, problems and categories.

In addition to its internecine struggles, developments and discontinuities within sociology and the sociology of education both reflect and respond to changes in society. However, there are neither inevitable nor direct relationships between social and political contexts and the preoccupations and dispositions of the academy where knowledge is produced. In addition, the work of the social sciences works back on society through the recontextualisation of the 'human sciences' within professional education, although less directly now than in the past (see below). 'Human science' knowledge functions politically and is intimately implicated in the practical management of social and political problems. The idea that human sciences like sociology stand outside or above the political agenda concerning the management of the population or somehow have a neutral status embodied in a free-floating, progressive rationalism is a dangerous and debilitating conceit. 'Scientific' or theoretical vocabularies may distance researchers from the subjects of their activity but, at the same time, it also constructs a 'gaze' that renders the 'landscape of the social' ever more visible and produces or contributes to discourses which create particular sorts of 'subject positions' for people to occupy. Moreover, governments are no longer content to wait for the harvest of 'good news' or new research ideas; they seek to engineer the crop. Policy desire shapes research offerings and increasingly significant and sensitive research for 'government' is out-sourced to the commercial sector (see Ball, 2007) rather than entrusted to the university sector. University based research is itself also increasingly subject to the 'authority and apparent objectivity of disciplines such as accountancy, economics and management' (MacKinnon, 2000: 297), through the operationalisation of concepts like 'quality' and 'policy-relevance' and mechanisms like the RAE (Research Assessment Exercise).

Political arithmetic

The beginnings of British sociology of education lay in a set of struggles in relation to **social eugenics** and the work of population studies, which was initiated and primarily disseminated from the London School of Economics, from the late 1930s to the late 1960s. Its methods and politics were driven by those of the LSE mainstream tradition of 'political arithmetic', a term taken from *Political Arithmetic: A Symposium of Population Studies* edited in 1938 by Lancelot Hogben (Hogben, 1938), physiological geneticist, experimental zoologist, medical statistician and one-time Fabian socialist.⁵ Hogben's collection included two papers by J.L. Gray and Pearl Moshinsky on 'Ability and Opportunity in English Education' and one by David V. Glass and J.L. Gray on 'Opportunity and the Older Universities'. Hogben describes the papers in this section of the book as opening 'a field of enquiry which has been conspicuously neglected and offers ample scope for investigations on class mobility and changing social structure' (Hogben, 1938: 333). He also wrote that 'the problem of social arithmetic is then to estimate the remediable wastage due to defective social organisation and the loss of social efficiency resulting there from' (Hogben, 1938: 332).

Hogben was 'the first, last and only' Professor of Social Biology at the LSE (1930–37),⁶ whose department undertook mathematical investigations bearing on human genetics, population growth, differential fertility and (with Louis Herrman) the responses of monozygotic and dizygotic twins to intelligence tests, becoming a centre for demography research. Hogben was an outspoken anti-eugenicist and his book was published in part as a response to a eugenicist panic in the 1930s around the issue of population decline and social class differentials in birth rates and ensuing debates about appropriate policy responses.⁷ One of the instigators of the debate was Enid Charles, his wife and a lecturer in his department at LSE, whose book *The Twilight of Parenthood*; when re-published in 1936, bore the title *The Menace of Under-Population*. There were two distinct parties in this debate: the eugenicists who were concerned that the 'wrong' citizens were reproducing while the right ones were not, provoking calls for forced sterilization;⁸ and those like Hogben, who argued for better use to be made of the population through raising the school leaving age and introducing universal secondary education, anticipating the post-war 'waste of talent' discourse. As Eggleston put it 'The social distribution of education identified by the research of sociologists became reidentified as the social maldistribution of educational opportunity' and 'Their evidence was used to particularly powerful effect by the advocates of secondary school reorganisation' (1976: 127).

Two different versions of population management in relation to the 'well-being of the state', with population as a political and scientific problem, were in contest here. On the one side were those who believed in the necessity of the exercise of biopower very directly upon specific individuals and their repro-

ductive practices in the regulation of the 'blood' of the nation seeing the use of state power as essential to its 'life'. Ranged against them were those who trusted to the more subtle disciplines of social welfare aimed at the population as a whole. These are different points of emphasis in the 'triangle, sovereignty-discipline-government, which has the population as its primary target' (Foucault, 1996), 'through the articulation and distribution of the different *dispositifs*' (Lazzarato nd.). The eugenicists represented and argued for a form of sovereign/disciplinary power which would be enacted directly upon the bodies of those parts of the population deemed to be responsible for the reproduction of dangerous and debilitating traits and behaviours. However, the government committee (the Brock Committee) set up in 1932 to report on the possibility of enforced sterilization to address the problem of policy recommended (in 1934) in favour of a programme of 'voluntary sterilization'. A recommendation that was in fact 'quietly forgotten as the cruelty of compulsory sterilization in Nazi Germany was exposed from the mid-1930s' (King and Hansen, 1999: 83). However, sterilization programmes did become law in Sweden and other countries (see Spektorowski and Mizrahi, 2004). In contrast the 'sociologists' were articulating a form of disciplinary/governmental power to be exercised through the institutions of education and the professional knowledge and practices of teachers, and welfare interventions into the lives of 'poor' families.

Interestingly, A.H. Halsey returned to these issues in a 1977 edited collection, *Heredity and Environment* (Halsey, 1977), his introduction concluding that 'it may well be that transmitted deprivation plays a relatively minor part in reproducing inequality in each new generation' (Halsey, 1977: 25). But interestingly, given its importance at the time, Halsey's (2004) *A History of Sociology in Britain* contains only three references to eugenics. Nonetheless, the 1930s debate, which set inheritance against environment, was to create the basic problematic for the sociology of education in terms of attempts to explain social class inequalities by social and environmental factors rather than personal and genetic ones.

During the late 1940s and 1950s LSE sociologists formed a 'self conscious network' (Fisher, 2007: 237) of 'men of the left' (Halsey, 2004: 42) which provided much of the intellectual underpinning for the post-war interventionist welfare state; although the LSE was also 'the most important centre of the revival of interest in economic liberal thinking from the early thirties onwards' (Cockett, 1994: 29), associated mainly with Hayek and Lionel Robbins. However, it was interventionist/welfarist approaches rather than market liberalism or eugenics at the LSE which dominated the post-war social reconstruction of Britain and placed education as one of the pillars of a modern welfare state, even though the bi- and tri-partite systems of secondary education set in place in the aftermath the 1944 Education Act were based upon principles of ability measurement which included some intelligence testing. The Norwood Report (1944) which recommended the tri-partite system certainly bears traces of eugenicist thinking in its confident assertion that the

education system had 'thrown up' three 'rough groupings' of children with three different 'types of mind'.

Building upon Hogben's research agenda the concerns of the handful of post-war researchers were focused initially upon problems of mass participation in the education system and the debilitating effects, for some children, of economic and material deprivation. The assumption of those at work at this time appeared to be that if such extrinsic sources of inequality could be removed or ameliorated the repeatedly evident and apparently tight bond between educational attainment and social class could be broken; leaving residual differences which could be explained in other ways, such as differential intelligence distribution or selection bias. This served to establish social class as the major, almost the only, preoccupation in research in the sociology of education for the next forty years. During this period, through the work of particular 'specific intellectuals', such as A.H. Halsey, the sociology of education aspired to and occasionally achieved a positive, influential relationship with policy-making. Halsey worked in what he termed the 'political arithmetic' tradition throughout his career, pursuing the dual tasks of documenting the state of society and addressing social and political issues through 'experimental social administration' as he called it. Both the discipline and its politics and its relationships to policy were set within the grooves of a redemptive, utopian modernism. Research linked to ameliorative state policies focused upon the achievement of equality **and** prosperity – the better educated we are the better off we are, individually and collectively. The discourse of this policy optimism was founded upon notions like the 'wasted pool of talent' and, later, 'compensatory education'. Particular policy solutions, like Social Priority Areas, were pursued, based upon outcomes drawing to some degree on empirical research, particularly by Labour governments.

Many of the early classic sociology of education texts have become forgotten or neglected but are well worth re-visiting in the light of contemporary debates, as are the appended bodies of evidence that accompanied each of the Central Advisory Council's Reports on education, from *Early Leaving*, via Crowther, Newsom and the Public Schools' Commission to Plowden. In the received wisdom, studies line JWB Douglas's (of the LSE Medical Research Council Unit) 1971 study *All our Future* (Douglas *et al.*, 1971), sequel to *The Home and the School* (Douglas, 1964) has become regarded as relying too heavily and unreflexively on a social pathology of the working class family. In fact, while generally these studies were concerned both with 'the impact of the family on the early processes of learning and on the acquisition of incentives' (Douglas, 1964: 160) and the independent effects of schooling and material conditions. Douglas and his colleagues are very clear that 'the type of school a child goes to has an increasingly important influence on his performance, as he grows older' (Douglas, 1964: 152). Indeed, these studies highlighted the importance of understanding class inequalities as part of a dynamic which links homes to schools **within** policy contexts of selection and ability grouping, emphasising that social inequalities are interlocking, multi-dimensional and compounding. Thus,

Floud et al. (1956), building on the work of Himmelweit (1954) sought in their comparison of social class and educational opportunity in Middlesbrough and South West Hertfordshire, to 'compare the influence on the success of working-class children in obtaining grammar school places of the material environment at school, the material environment at home, and the "cultural" environment at home' (Floud *et al.*: 92).⁹ This first wave work in the sociology of education, while it did at times talk about 'deficiencies of interest and ambition on the part of parents' (Floud *et al.*: 188–189), Floud using the term '*la famille educogene*', did not simply ignore the effects of the school in the production of opportunities and inequalities related to social class.

However, neither the optimism attached to the welfare state nor that embedded in the practices and discourses of the sociology of education lasted. The latter's Fabian-style reformism was dramatically and decisively occluded in the 1970s by a short-lived 'naïve possibilitarianism' (see below) and subsequently various forms of radical pessimism. Whereas, as in the 1930s, the 'debate' about education still sought to relate system characteristics to issues of general economic efficiency and international competitiveness, the usual policy terms became an irrelevance in the sociology of education of the 1970s as reproduction of unequal social relations were discovered, not only to be lurking stubbornly in every classroom nook and cranny and every staffroom conversation, but rooted in the abstract needs of the state and the inevitable and inescapable requirements and workings of the economy. Such a shift in sociological gaze from families and homes and formal processes of institutional selection and allocation to classrooms and classroom knowledge and the untoward requirements of the state, entailed a thorough-going reconstitution of the sociological problematic of education and a de-naturalising of its knowledge and institutional processes. *Education was no longer the solution but the problem.* Teachers came into this gaze as both 'transgressive intellectuals' and as 'political dopes' and became the subject of derision from both the sociological left and political right for failing to deliver either fairness (as carriers of the reproductive requirements of capital) or national economic prosperity (as dangerous political subversives). As a result of this shift of focus the professional enclave of teachers and their knowledges would be increasingly and thoroughly breached and the sociology of education would, unintentionally for the most part, play its part in reworking the relations of power between teachers and the state through the production of a new 'surface of emergence' for policy which re-constructed the school as an object of management science (see Ball, 2008) and latterly 'leadership' (see Gunter, 2001).

The new sociology of education

For the New Sociology of Education (NSE) a relationship between research and policy (at least at national level) seemed not just pointless but politically incorrect. Many of the growing number of sociologists of education, who

served rapidly expanding and upgrading initial education and in-service accreditation for teachers and who did little or no research themselves, found themselves grounded between negativity and complicity. At the same time, with the collapse during the 1970s of the formal and constructive relationship between educational research and policy at the national level and a growing suspicion of liberal expertise within educational politics, a vacuum was created in the arena of educational policy-making which was skilfully filled for a time by organic intellectuals of the new right (such as Roger Scruton, Caroline Cox, Stuart Sexton, Digby Anderson, Rhodes Boyson, Sig Prais) who were determined to fight for continuing, formal secondary school selection by ability in the face of 'comprehensive' reorganisation, a reversal of 'child centred' or 'progressive' pedagogic modalities, and in defence of the canonical curriculum against the inroads of new forms of school knowledge (see Ball, 1990). They brought their own 'research' to bear on the issues. At the political level, critique of comprehensive schooling by the Right (particularly via the *Black Papers*, 1969–77) and what Johnson calls the 'forming of the New Right educational tendency' and the entry of government into 'the secret garden of the curriculum' (1991: 35–44) was mirrored and partly enabled by the opening up of the school for new kinds of research and analysis by the NSE. The 'left' critique of welfare schooling, in particular its relationship to and 'disempowerment' of the working class through classed knowledge and classed pedagogies, played its part in the transfer of 'pathologies' from home and family to school and teachers. The school was to become the new sociological laboratory, and practising teachers were subject to an unrelenting critical research gaze – an 'optics of power'. Alongside this, in 1976, James Callaghan in his Ruskin Speech on education announced the 'great education debate', challenging the monopoly of teacher education and educationalists over questions about the methods and purposes of education: he said 'I take it that no one claims exclusive rights in this field'. This presaged an entirely new relationship between the state and education and the 'management' of education through the sciences of calculation and disciplines of measurement (see below).

Symbolically, at least, the 'moment' of interruption of the hegemony of political arithmetic in the sociology of education came in 1971 with the publication of the book *Knowledge and Control: New Directions in the Sociology of Education*, edited by M.F.D. Young (Young, 1971), a former student of Basil Bernstein at Essex University, by then a colleague at the IOE. Bernstein, one of the LSE 'Group of Thirteen' (Fisher, 2007) (which also included Halsey, David Glass and Olive Banks), whose seminal paper 'On the classification and framing of educational knowledge', originally given as the closing address at the BSA conference in Durham in 1970, was first published in the collection, is quite wrongly identified as a key figure in the NSE (see below).¹⁰ *Knowledge and Control*, whose contents included two papers by Bourdieu and contributions by Robin Horton and Ioan Davies, in addition to pieces by Young and his Masters' students, Keddie and Esland, set about, in a wide variety of terms, to re-focus the sociology of education on the substance and processes of educa-

tion rather than its organisation and distribution or its mediation of cultural and material inequalities; to get 'inside the black box' of schooling as Lacey (1970) put it. Young posed the question: 'what sort of education is it that working class students fail at?' The book's publication came at a time of expansion in teacher education provision and movement to all-graduate status through exposure to courses that still retained substantial elements of the 'disciplines of education', usually including some sociology. There were, in the early seventies, for example, 32 Teacher Education institutions in the University of London, Institute of Education ATO (Area Training Organisation). Through the 1970s, as Green and Whitty (1994: 7) point out: 'Sociologically, NSE was part of a professionalising occupational structure which simultaneously experienced a process of professional segmentation and sharper identity formation as it staked its claim for inclusion in higher education'. The sociology of education, like only a few other of sociology's sub-fields (eg medical and criminal), had a 'captive audience' which provided a firm and expanding structure of employment. During the brief decade of disciplinary expansion of sociology of education in initial teacher education after 1967, sociology of education Diploma and Masters' programmes, which were always at the IOE composed of sharply contrasting offerings by old and newly directed colleagues (see Davies, 1994), processed a generation of NSE scholars, fellow travellers and erstwhile critics including Nell Keddie, Geoff Esland, John Beck, Madan Sarup, John Bartholomew, Dave Gorbitt, Ian Hextall, Rachel Sharp, Tony Green, Geoff Whitty, Chris Jencks, Denis Gleeson and George Mardle, who would go on to elaborate, disseminate and critique its various forms across the UK and beyond. However, CATE (Committee for the Accreditation of Teacher Education), created in 1984 by the Conservative government, replaced discipline-based teacher education with a classroom skills/competences version of teacher training. The sociology of education and other foundation disciplines of education, apart from some elements of psychology, were deemed both irrelevant and politically dangerous for would-be practitioners, who, rather than have sociology thrust upon them, became free to choose and pay for sociology, as part of higher degree qualifications, often packaged as part of policy, behaviour management, assessment or curriculum courses.

The NSE was self-consciously 'radical', in its assertions of a fundamental mismatch between the 'middle-class' character of 'school knowledge' and working class culture and teachers' complicity in its reproduction, in contrast to what it regarded as the 'bad faith' of the redemptive 'reformism' of the political arithmetic (PA) tradition. The NSE focused on 'radical' and alternative forms of practice linked to the equal worth of everyday or 'commonsense' knowledge and its conventional, specialised forms, in contrast to PA's concern with policy and the management of the system:

They saw that the 'old' approach to the sociology of education reinforced the view that social justice has not been well served by comprehensivisation

and that the distribution of social possibilities was not being dramatically 'equalised', but they were less willing to accept that nothing could be done about it. (Green and Whitty, 1994: 8).

Whitty refers to the early days of the NSE as marked by 'over-optimistic excesses' and a 'naïve possibilitarianism' which were soon, however, displaced by the 'espousal of forms of Marxism that seemed to deny the 'open human possibilities for change' (Whitty, 1985: 3). Indeed, NSE was never a single, coherent alternative to PA but an odd and unstable amalgam of 'segments' and idiolects which drew upon existentialism and phenomenology, various Marxisms (Althusser, Poulantzas, Gramsci, and US political economy), interactionisms (symbolic interactionism and Manchester anthropology) and sociologies of knowledge (see Whitty, 1985 for a synoptic account).

As Moore explained the NSE writers 'were preoccupied with the problem of the relationship between three areas: social structure; situational (or classroom analysis): and the possibilities of radical change' (Moore, 1988: 5). The tensions between them were well demonstrated and rehearsed in the first, highly popular Open University course, E282 *School and Society* in 1972 and in 1977 its expanded successor, E202, and their widely used course material and Readers. Moore (1988) refers to a 'fundamental ambiguity' in the relationship between the NSE and what he calls 'phenomenological sociology', positions which have roughly evolved into a more extensive and diverse tradition, what Noblit and Pink (1995) call, respectively, *critical* and *interpretative*. If these OU courses may properly be regarded as the most public site where these positions were represented, the moment and possibilities of both integration and abstraction seem to have passed by the time the 1972 *School and Society* Reader (Cosin *et al.*, 1972), a key text in the dissemination of early NSE thinking, was replaced by separate readers, *Schooling and Capitalism* (Dale *et al.*, 1976) and *The Processes of Schooling* (Hammersley and Woods, 1976) representing neo-Marxist and interpretative perspectives, respectively. These supplanted Halsey, A.H., Floud, J. and Anderson, C.A. (eds) (1961) *Education, Economy and Society* as the major source of readings for sociology of education courses.¹¹ Also during the 1970s, Sharp and Green's *Education and Social Control* (Sharp and Green, 1975), and Willis's *Learning to Labour* (Willis, 1977), both neo-Marxist ethnographies of schooling whose authors would not see themselves as part of the NSE, became key points of reference for NSE teaching, along with Bowles and Gintis's *Schooling in Capitalist America* (Bowles and Gintis, 1976), posing basic epistemological and ontological tensions between neo-Marxism and interactionism. In particular, difficulties in resolving macro/micro materialist/idealist, negotiated/structured social reality and structure/process were continuing grist to continuing tensions and critiques¹². These tensions were played out in a series of annual sociology of education conferences founded by Len Barton and held at Westhill College, Birmingham, and in the pages of the *British Journal of Sociology of Education* (BJSE), founded in 1979 and edited by Len Barton (as it still is). Together the

conference and the journal provided a national but still partial disciplinary infrastructure for British sociology of education.

Outside the UK, the inheritors of some of the promise and possibilities of NSE have been American theorists and researchers like Apple, Giroux, McLaren and Wexler each of whom, in different ways, has fused Marxism, interactionism and the sociology of knowledge into a set of multi-purpose, critical, analytic tools (see Apple, 1996 for a discussion) though the mainstream of their discipline in the US remained largely uninterested in and unaware of their existence.

Bernstein and the NSE

Despite his iconic status in the sociology of education, and his influence over specific groups of education researchers, nationally and internationally, Bernstein was never part of NSE, apart from being instrumental in securing the publication of Young's collection, and indeed was a trenchant critic of many of its constituents and particularly damning of its weak empirical basis. Whitty's (1985) book *Sociology and School Knowledge*, contains only passing mentions of Bernstein while the work of Young, Lawton and others is discussed in detail. Bernstein's singularity is most evident in the fecundity of his theory, which entailed a lifelong commitment to and use of Durkheimian sociological ideas and practice (as well as theorists of language from Saussure to Halliday, Mead and latterly Foucault and a variety of neo-Marxist) and marked him out from political arithmeticians, 'dedicated' neo-Marxists and interpretative sociologists of education and latterly from post-structuralists. For a time he was engaged in a fruitful exchange of ideas with Bourdieu, whose work was also influenced by Durkheim, among others, whose general influence in UK sociology of education has been pervasive but very indirect (see Moore, 2006).

In the 1970s there were few sociologists of education interested in taking up Bernstein's challenge to produce an empirically grounded theory of the construction of pedagogic discourse, its distributive, recontextualising and evaluative rules, and their social basis. In addition to an already established research genre focused on sociolinguistic issues going back to the late sixties, from which he turned his attention to pedagogy in the early seventies, Bernstein's studies of education were initially conducted by his research students, developing since the early 1980s around a set of key scholars in specific locations (see Muller and Morais, 2004), until recently little read or cited even by those who used his ideas.

While in the 1970s the sociology of education in the UK had moved decisively away from the LSE to the twin epicentres of the IOE and Open University, as well as locations, such as Manchester, Leicester and Keele, the work of PA continued, based at Nuffield College, Oxford. In a review of *Origins and Destination* (Halsey *et al.*, 1980), a cohort study of persistent patterns of class

inequality in education in the BJSE in 1981, Martyn Hammersley, a key contributor to the Open University interactionist output in its sociology of education courses, described the authors as 'imprisoned in their own fossilised tradition' and remarked that 'it is extraordinary that after ten years of massive political, theoretical and methodological upheaval in the sociology of education they can produce a book which reflects so little the changes that have occurred in this period' (Hammersley, 1981: 95). In their response Heath, Halsey and Ridge asserted that: 'Our own view of the future for the political arithmetic tradition is not quite so gloomy, however. We see it as a developing tradition, evolving new techniques of analysis, hybridising with related species and occupying a distinct and secure ecological niche' (Heath *et al.*, 1982: 87). Writing in more general terms in his *History of British Sociology* Halsey referred to the 'fatal' consequences of the 'debilitating antagonism' and 'mutual incomprehension' existing between 'scientifically trained sociologists and innumerate products of the schools of cultural studies' (2004: 26).

The flight to policy: school effectiveness (SE) and organisational studies.

In the 1980s the undisputed dominance of class analysis was displaced as the primary variable in sociology of education. Race, gender (clearly recognised by Bernstein and others as crucial, linked aspects of stratification) and, later, disability and sexual orientation, came to the fore both in analytical perspectives and in new, tentative liaisons between theory and practice, bringing into play new specialised languages and theoretical idiolects with their attendant 'competences' and 'literacies'. As their standpoint epistemologies crystallised, possibilities of conceptual integration became increasingly elusive. Some one-time and would-be sociologists and other educational researchers now reinvented themselves as feminists or anti-racists, bringing to educational studies an infusion of invigorating new theory. Others took on new identities as curriculum and policy analysts and yet others as organisation (and later management) theorists, and 'school effectiveness' researchers (to be distinguished from the longstanding and painstaking tradition of 'school effects' research and scholarship in the US). It is to school effectiveness (SE) research that I want to turn at this point, although a good case might be made that this is was never really sociology at all. But it does illustrate some significant and 'inconvenient' continuities at work in and around the sociology of education, as well as the dispersal of sociological sensibilities into other fields, and it does mark out a set of struggles over what is to count as the sociology of education (see Angus below). An examination of SE also indicates a new kind of political relation of educational research to education policy, and the construction of a new 'gaze' for research and for policy.

In the UK school effectiveness work originated with the modest and incomplete empirical work of David Reynolds and his associates, driven by their view of the effectness of the middle-class individualism of NSE aspirations to 'save' the lower orders from the depredation of their schooling (Reynolds and

Sullivan, 1980). Out of this work, a new relationship *to* policy or, rather, *inside* policy was forged, culminating in the establishing of a DfEE Standards and Effectiveness Unit, headed from 1997 to 2002 by Professor Michael Barber:

This country led the world in the study of school effectiveness but lagged behind in applying its lessons. This is no longer true. Furthermore, the interest in school effectiveness and school improvement goes far beyond schools. Many LEAs [...] have begun to develop a forward-looking, creative role promoting and encouraging school improvement [...] And school effectiveness fever (sic) can be found at national level too. The Department for Education has a School Effectiveness Division which displays a refreshing humility and whose decisions are evidently informed by research. The OFSTED framework, though far from perfect, is laced through with an understanding of school effectiveness. (Barber, 1998: 18)

The claims of effectiveness and school-difference studies were read, by governments determined to keep differential school intakes off the agenda, as sufficient evidence for firmly re-centring the school as the focus of causation in explanations of student performance and variations in levels of achievement; thereby displacing or rendering silent other explanations related to the embeddedness of education in social and economic contexts. Insofar as the gaze of 'effectiveness' provided a scientific basis for the possibility of 'blaming' the school, it fitted perfectly in terms of theoretical unity into the 'new right' discourses of derision which targeted them as 'causes' of general social and economic problems within society. In addition, the focus on measurable outcomes also articulated directly with the political process of the commodification of education involved in the creation of an education market. Furthermore, this research provided a scientific concomitant to the political re-emphasis on excellence, diversity and selection and the attempt to develop methods of appraisal which could be used to identify (and punish) 'weak' and 'inadequate' teachers. This would, in the 1990s under New Labour, lead to the imposition of systems of incentive and performance related pay. Effectiveness studies developed a technology of control – a 'threshold of describability' – which enabled the monitoring and 'steering' of schools by applying 'neutral' indicators and continually attempting to 'tap' and measure more of that which is schooling, including 'the "deep structure" of pupil attitudes and perceptions' (Reynolds, 1990: 21). Intentions that may initially have been 'socialist' and egalitarian thus fashioned the means whereby significant discursive and disciplinary work was done by the polyvalent application of effectiveness research to policy interest in generating a language and a set of technologies for the management of schools, constituted as 'an object for a branch of knowledge' (Foucault, 1979: 191). This was done through the work of Ofsted and school inspections, the naming and shaming of 'failing schools' and the development of an infrastructure of testing and league tables.

Nonetheless, there are also important continuities here with the original problematic of the sociology of education – relationships between policy, schooling and opportunity. The argument made by some school effectiveness researchers was that schools with very similar intake demographics produced very different outcomes in terms of student achievement, so that explanation of under-achievement among socially disadvantaged groups could, to a great extent, be located in the differences between schools in terms of organisation, ethos, teaching quality and leadership. This effectively displaced both social class (and ethnicity) and student characteristics (including intelligence) as explanatory variables and collapsed this segment of the sociology of education into a form of organisational studies. That is to say, inequalities could be resolved by the generation of the correct school ‘ethos’ or appropriate forms of school ‘leadership’. As a form of sociological practice, effectiveness also promised a return to a numerate empiricism and avoidance of theoretical encumbrances. It might also be argued that there is also a continuity between the work of the NSE and the classroom and institutional studies (eg Hargreaves, 1967; Lacey, 1970 and Ball, 1981) of the 1970s and 1980s which identified pathological teachers and schools as key elements of the machinery of class failure, and the logic of effectiveness. There is no simple innocence or virtue or independence in any of these forms of sociology.

Nonetheless, as it was translated into policy, effectiveness operates as a technology of normalisation. Such research both constructs a normative model of the effective school and abnormalises the ineffective or ‘sick’ school.

A medical analogy may be helpful. The treatment that a sick person needs to recover is different from the regime that will make an ordinary person fit. Indeed a fitness regime imposed on invalids may make them worse. The same seems to apply to schools; competence must precede excellence (Stark, 1998: 36).

The normalising effects of ‘effectiveness’ are noted by Laurie Angus where, in a review of school effectiveness literature, he comments that ‘predictability and efficiency are valued to the extent that schools would surely become dramatically more boring places than they are already’ (Angus, 1993: 343). He goes on to suggest that:

not only is there a lack of engagement with sociological (or other theory), but also effectiveness work is largely trapped in a logic of common sense which allows it, by and large, to be appropriated into the Right’s hegemonic project [. . .] it advocates an isolationist, apolitical approach to education in which it is assumed that educational problems can be fixed by technical means and inequality can be managed within the walls of schools and classrooms provided that teachers and pupils follow ‘correct’ effective school procedures (Angus, 1993: 343).

The identification of sickness in the social body of schools, articulated within 'a system of formal equality' (Foucault, 1979: 184), and produced through functional and hierarchical measurements, works to justify and require the application of the arts of intervention. And these arts were exercised via the concepts of 'review', 'development planning' 'self-evaluation' and appraisal, among others. These latter day techniques of organisational confession (both as admissions of transgression and rituals of atonement) operate as a means of the submission and transformation of schools into a new generic organisational form.

As almost a mirror image of the school, family, social class nexus of the educational studies of the 1950s and 1960s school effectiveness has contributed to a new *zeitgeist* for educational reform since the 1990s. Social contexts and social demographics are stripped away to 'expose' and position schools in isolation; to be inspected, evaluated and compared by 'the difference' they make. The social patterns and economic trends which link together large numbers of failing schools, especially in the secondary sector, are systematically neglected in the attention given to leadership, vision, management, and ethos. Teachers and head teachers generally are rendered as ensembles of skills and competences – depersonalised and stripped of commitments, passions and desires (Ball, 2004). Teachers' professionalism is no longer an effective means of assuring docility and productivity. Indeed their exercise of professional judgement is seen as a threat to good order and an appropriately prepared workforce. By removing context and complexity, school effectiveness renders education or at least schooling eminently more manageable and malleable. It translates directly into judgement and 'improvement'. It feeds into what Thrupp (1998) calls the 'politics of blame'. Furthermore, there is a strange reversal of the analytic tropes of both PA and NSE. First, 'Knowledge and curriculum are generally regarded as unproblematic and it is assumed that students must simply learn them' (Angus, 1993: 343). Secondly, home-school relationships are homogenised and reduced to the anodyne rhetoric of partnership. 'Neglect of pupil cultures and family cultures, which are also class cultures means a neglect of agency' (Hatcher, 1996: 40). Once again there is an intellectual trade between government and educational studies and a new economy of policy ideas from research.

Conclusion

What Bernstein's (1999) rather gloomy account of the sociology of education lacks perhaps, despite its obvious insights and clarity, is a sense of the history of the discipline and a recognition of the moments at which language, structure and gaze were unified or offered the possibility of unity. Political Arithmetic was one such moment when a sociological idiolect was constructed over and against the languages and speakers of both eugenics and psychology and to some extent neo-liberalism. Although clearly history demonstrates that these

'others' to sociology were never completely displaced or dispensed with. The NSE was another moment, however fleeting, at which the sociology of education was constructed around a problem and its vicissitudes – the problem of knowledge. But generally Bernstein's rendition of sociology and its travails is painfully accurate. Sociology is a space of contention and, perhaps, as an intellectual practice and as a worldly endeavour that is its strength as well as its inherent weakness. Nonetheless, the sociology of education and its outliers in educational studies continue, directly and indirectly, to generate new forms of optics through which schools, teachers and students, are re-organised, re-structured, and regulated.

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Notes

- 1 The important points of turmoil around feminism and postmodernism are not dealt with here.
- 2 School effectiveness both was and was not 'sociology' and 'sociological'. It certainly involved claims which reconstructed the relationships between social class and educational achievement, and re-invented the positivist, quantitative methods of Political Arithmetic. It also established a new relation of research to policy which had been lost to the sociology of education during the 1970s and 1980s.
- 3 I am very grateful to Tony Green and Geoff Whitty for talking to me about their experiences of the NSE at the IOE, to Meg Maguire for her thoughtful responses to an earlier draft of this paper, and particularly to Brian Davies for his careful and insightful work on the text and his efforts to make my history more coherent.
- 4 Clearly what constitutes the field and histories of US, French or German sociology of education would look very different. I cannot attempt to encompass those national differences here.
- 5 However, the term Political Arithmetic was originally coined by Sir William Petty (May 27, 1623–December 16, 1687), an English economist, scientist and philosopher, who declared that his form of science would only use measurable phenomena and would seek quantitative precision, rather than rely on comparatives or superlatives, yielding a new subject that he named *political arithmetic*.
- 6 The next director of the LSE, (Sir) Alexander Carr-Saunders, was also a social biologist with whom Hogben felt he was unlikely to get on. They had met in the 1920s with Julian Huxley, Carr-Saunders was on the Council of the Eugenics Education Society from 1920, Editor of the *Eugenics Review* (1920–27), Vice-President of the Eugenics Society (1936–39) and its President (1949–53).
- 7 In 1932 the minister of health appointed a special committee to report and make recommendations on the sterilization of the 'feeble-minded' in England and Wales – which it did in 1934, recommending a programme of 'voluntary sterilization'.
- 8 Fabianism in general and the LSE in particular had a long and close association with eugenics and J.M. Keynes, Julian Huxley and William Beveridge all sat on the Council of the Eugenics Society.
- 9 Jean Floud had been research assistant to Karl Mannheim at the LSE in the 1930s and became University of London Reader in the Sociology of Education at the IOE from 1956–62 to be succeeded by Basil Bernstein who, following his undergraduate experience at LSE had gone into FE teaching and part-, then full-time, sociolinguistic research at University College London.
- 10 The 1970 BSA conference was the only one to focus on Education as a key theme.

- 11 Although there have been two further iterations of this collection, Halsey, A.H., Lauder, H., Brown, P. and Stuart Wells, A. (eds) (1997) *Education: Culture, Economy and Society*, Oxford University Press, Oxford. and more recently Lauder, H., Brown, P., Jo-Anne, Dillabough and Halsey, A.H. (eds) (2006) *Education, Globalization and Social Change*, Oxford University Press, Oxford.
- 12 In a book *Bowles and Gintis Revisited* (1988) Cole boldly described the publication of Schooling in Capitalist America as 'at last a resolution of the shortcoming of NSE – in particular its inability to link micro to macro' (p. 7).

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